

Research, the Referral Network, and What Comes Next

For Matt Campbell, from Chris Habetler. September 29, 2026.

Matt,

I'm really excited about this. On the 22nd you asked what I could do, what it would look like, and what I would charge, so I took a stab at it. Read it as a starting point. I'm looking forward to talking it through and figuring out the best path together, and I expect we'll change a good bit of it.

The short version: I want to be a real part of your team as EdTech Expertz grows. Right now that means taking research and the day-to-day of the referral network off your desk, so the five leads you've been holding don't stall once you open them up. After that, it means being someone you can call on for whatever comes up next.

What I'd Take On

Here's what I've heard you need so far. There's no count of reports or hours on any of it. You call on me for what you need.

- In-depth research whenever you need it: crosswalks, diligence readouts like Knowlej and Forward Edge, prep briefs on prospective clients, and people maps. This is the "30 people at Canvas" version, where the research comes back with more than you asked for. You get a PDF and a Markdown file for your own AI ahead of the meeting.
- Running the referral network day to day: finding and vetting new members and having the first conversation with each one (you approve and send the contract), onboarding, a one-page card on each company, monthly check-ins, running the monthly meeting with you, a weekly digest so you can say yes or no in one pass, the tracker in your Drive, and the shared diligence folder we talked about. Members can still come straight to you whenever they want, and your clients still go through you to reach the network.
- The school-side voice in client work: sessions like Forward Edge on 10/1, messaging and language work like the ClassE guide, feedback on decks and pitches, and bringing in an expert reviewer when a client needs one (Gerrit for ELA, for example).
- Introductions in both directions: school leaders under the agreement we signed in August, and people who can help your clients or your business.
- Helping build what's next when you're ready. AI enablement for school leaders is my lane, and I'd be glad to help with L&D and associations too.

Anything else that helps EdTech Expertz grow, send it my way.

To keep it simple, a short weekly check-in where you set the priorities. If the work ever outgrows the pay, or the pay outgrows the work, we'll both see it there and talk about it.

For the first month, my priorities would be prep briefs on your five parked leads, the member list cleaned up, the company cards, and the first weekly digest.

What stays yours: the company relationships, approving intros, contracts, fees, and the final call on positioning. Everything I build lives in your Drive and belongs to you, including the agent prompt you asked about in July.

Pay

Where I'd want this to end up once your business has grown into it is \$5,000 a month. For scale, one new client the size of ClassE is \$8,500 a month, so if this helps you bring on even one of the five leads, it covers that. I know October isn't the month for it, so here are three ways to get there. I'd recommend the second.

1. Full rate from the start: \$5,000 a month, plus 15% of what EdTech Expertz keeps on network deals.
2. Start lower and grow into it (my recommendation): \$2,500 a month to start, plus 20% of what EdTech Expertz keeps on network deals.
3. The least cash now: \$1,500 a month plus 30% of what EdTech Expertz keeps on network deals. The share drops to 20% once the base reaches \$5,000. Getting there from \$1,500 would take about three new clients the size of ClassE.

Whichever you pick, it starts on October 1 or the day AAP signs, whichever is later. AAP counts as part of today's business, not as a new client. Benchmark and Forward Edge on 10/1 are on me no matter when we start.

You floated 1% of everything as a placeholder. I went with a bigger share of a narrower slice, network deals only, so it never touches your core consulting.

How It Grows

This is your "floor bumps up, percentage bumps up" idea, with the triggers written down. The same rules apply to all three options.

- The base grows with new clients. Each new retainer client you sign adds 15% of that client's monthly fee to my base, until it reaches \$5,000. A client the size of ClassE adds about \$1,275, so two like that would get us to the full rate. Smaller clients move it less. If a client that moved the base leaves, the base steps back down with it.
- The percentage grows with the network. Once network deals bring EdTech Expertz more than \$25,000 in a year, 20% becomes 25%.
- Bigger projects get their own number. If a client pays you for work I do most of, we agree on my share before it starts.
- January is the "bang-up job" check. We sit down and look at what I delivered (leads opened, the health of the network, the research you actually used) along with the numbers, and reset anything that needs it.

A network deal means a deal you close with a company through a member intro that you approved, logged in the tracker when you approved it. I'll never pitch members, since you've been clear this can't turn into a sales engine. My own intros stay under the August agreement, and if an intro fits both, the August agreement applies, so nothing gets paid twice.

Either of us can end this with 30 days' notice, and you'd get a clean handoff. The network share keeps paying for 12 months on deals already logged.

Items for Conversation

1. A full-time role. I'm in late rounds for a full-time role at a charter network, and there may be others. If one happens, you'll hear it from me first, and I want to keep doing both. What we'd work out together is timing (the network check-ins are the piece most tied to the school day) and anything a school employer would want to clear, since the network puts vendors in front of schools.
2. What you usually keep on a network deal. That number tells us whether the percentage is right.

3. Sharing each new client's monthly fee with me so the base can move. If you'd rather not, a flat \$1,000 per new retainer client works too.
4. How many hours a week research and the network take you now.
5. The ClassE advisory. You asked on 9/16 what I'd need. My starting thought is \$3,000 a month, and I'd want your read on how to frame it with Joe and where that work ends and my work for you begins.
6. Which new line you'd want to go after first.

Obviously there's a lot here. I'm really looking forward to talking it through and figuring out what works best for you. Clarity is king, so push on any of it.

Chris